

The New Jersey Home Buyer's Guide

Financing, house hunting, and closing — in plain language, with the NJ-specific details other guides skip. 2026 edition.

1. Get your financing sorted first

As of mid-2026, 30-year fixed mortgage rates are running roughly 6.4%–6.6%, and most housing economists expect rates to stay above 6% for the rest of the year. That makes a pre-approval — not just a pre-qualification — your first real step. A pre-approval means a lender has actually verified your income, credit, and assets, and sellers in competitive NJ towns will often ignore offers that aren't backed by one.

- **Shop at least 3 lenders.** Rates and closing costs vary more than people expect for the same borrower profile.
- **Ask about NJ-specific first-time buyer programs** through NJHMFA (NJ Housing and Mortgage Finance Agency), which offers down payment assistance and below-market rates for eligible buyers.
- **Budget for NJ's property taxes** — among the highest in the country and a major factor in monthly affordability, not just the mortgage payment.

2. What's different about buying in New Jersey

- **Attorney review period.** After an offer is accepted, both sides typically have a 3-business-day attorney review period during which either attorney can cancel or modify the deal. Many buyers don't realize this exists until they're in it — your agent should walk you through it.
- **Property taxes vary town to town.** Two similarly priced homes ten minutes apart can have very different tax bills depending on the municipality and school district. Always get the actual tax bill, not just an estimate, before making an offer.
- **North vs. Central vs. South Jersey.** North Jersey (NYC commuter towns) tends to run hottest and most expensive; the Shore counties see seasonal demand swings; South Jersey is generally more affordable with a slower pace. Your priorities — commute, schools, lifestyle — should drive the region, not just the price tag.
- **Inspections matter.** Older NJ housing stock means radon, oil tanks (above and underground), septic systems, and aging roofs/HVAC show up often. Budget for a full inspection, plus a radon and oil tank sweep in towns with older homes.

3. The house-hunting to closing timeline

Total time from accepted offer to keys is usually 45–60 days for a financed purchase, faster for cash.

- **Get pre-approved** (a few days to a week).
- **Tour homes with an agent** who knows your target towns cold — this is where a good referral pays off.
- **Make an offer**, often with an escalation strategy in competitive towns.
- **Attorney review** (3 business days, NJ-specific).
- **Home inspection** and negotiation of repairs or credits.
- **Mortgage underwriting and appraisal** (typically 30–45 days).
- **Final walkthrough and closing**.

Why the agent match matters

A buyer's agent who closes deals regularly in your target towns will know which houses are overpriced, which sellers are motivated, and how to structure an offer that wins without overpaying. That's the entire reason to get matched with a proven agent instead of picking a random name off a listing sign.

Ready for the next step? I'll match you with a proven local agent — screened on verified sales performance — at no cost to you. Call or text **(848) 216-8484**, email **John.T.Grossi@gmail.com**, or visit the contact page on the website.

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